



WEDNESDAY

MAY 14, 2025
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180-day entry visa for Blue Visa hopefuls

ABU DHABI
BY ABDULLA RASHEED
Abu Dhabi Editor

Individuals eligible for UAE's 10-year Blue Visa but outside the country are urged to apply for a 180-day multiple-entry visa to undertake the application process for the long-term residency permit.

The Federal Authority for Identity, Citizenship, Customs and Port Security (ICP) has begun accepting applications for a 180-day entry visa.

The Blue Residency is granted to those who have made exceptional contributions to environmental protection, sustainability, and clean energy. Eligible applicants include distinguished influencers, scientists and researchers with global recognition (nominated with the UAE Scientists Council's approval), investors and entrepreneurs in sustainability fields, and professionals working in environmental institutions in the UAE.

Round-the-clock access

The ICP offers round-the-clock access to the service via its website and smart app, with simplified procedures. To apply, users must submit documents, pay fees, and receive confirmation via email. The process takes around seven minutes, with approvals issued in one working day. Required documents include a valid passport, personal photo, and proof of eligibility.

SEE ALSO P2

US, Saudi Arabia ink massive \$142 billion arms agreement

US PRESIDENT WILL HEAD TO QATAR AND UAE IN NEXT TWO LEGS OF HIS VISIT

RIYADH

Saudi Arabia yesterday promised billions of dollars in deals with the United States from defence to artificial intelligence as it threw a lavish welcome for President Donald Trump on the first state visit of his second term.

The Saudis escorted Air Force One into the kingdom with fighter jets before bringing out long-stretching guards of honour and sending flag-waving cavalry to accompany Trump's motorcade to the palace.

The White House said that Saudi Arabia would buy nearly \$142 billion in weapons in what it described as the largest-ever weapons deal, although Trump in his first term trumpeted a larger, longer-term figure.

"The United States and Saudi Arabia signed the largest defence sales agreement in history — nearly \$142 billion, providing Saudi Arabia with state-of-the-art warfighting equipment," the White House said in a statement.

According to a Saudi official close to the defence ministry, Riyadh had been pushing to secure the latest US F-35 fighter jets along with state-of-the-art air defence systems worth billions of dollars.

AI investments

The White House said that Saudi company DataVolt will invest \$20 billion in artificial intelligence-related sites in the United States, while tech firms including Google will invest in both countries — welcome



AFP

■ A handout picture provided by the Saudi Royal Palace shows Saudi Crown Prince Mohammad Bin Salman welcoming US President Donald Trump upon his arrival in Riyadh yesterday.

news for Saudi Arabia which has long faced restrictions in US advanced technology.

Under imposing chandeliers, Trump welcomed a promise by Saudi Arabia's Crown Prince Mohammad Bin Salman for \$600 billion in investment and quipped that it should be \$1 trillion.

With cameras rolling, a lengthy procession of Saudi royalty and business figures waited their turn to shake hands with Trump and the crown prince, including Elon

Musk, the world's richest person and close adviser to Trump, who made a rare appearance in a suit.

The US leader will head later in the week to Qatar and the UAE, fellow oil-rich Arab countries with long-standing ties to the United States — and to Trump.

Eight years ago, Trump also chose Saudi Arabia for his first overseas trip — when he posed with a glowing orb and participated in a sword dance.

The country has also in-

creasingly exercised diplomatic clout, serving as a venue for the United States to pursue talks with Ukraine and Russia.

Qatar and the UAE have also sought international roles, with the Qataris serving as a mediator along with the United States and Egypt in the Israel-Hamas conflict.

Jon Alterman, senior vice president at the Center for Strategic and International Studies, said that for Trump, the Gulf "is his happy place".

— AFP

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83m internally displaced globally

Number of displaced people equivalent to Germany's population

GENEVA

Raging conflicts, disasters and worsening climate change displaced tens of millions of people within their own countries last year, a new report, monitors said yesterday.

An unprecedented 83.4 million internally displaced people (IDPs) were registered in 2024 — equivalent to the entire population of Germany — amid mass displacement from conflicts in places like Sudan and Gaza, as well as floods and giant cyclones. That is more than double the number from just six years

90%

of world's IDPs were displaced by conflict and violence

ago, the Internal Displacement Monitoring Centre (IDMC) and the Norwegian Refugee Council (NRC) said in their annual joint report on internal displacement.

The monitors highlighted that nearly 90 per cent of the world's IDPs, or 73.5 million people, were displaced by conflict and violence — an 80-per cent increase since 2018. Some 10 countries each counted more than three million IDPs from

conflict and violence at the end of 2024, with civil war-ravaged Sudan alone home to a staggering 11.6 million IDPs — the most ever recorded in a single country, the report showed.

Some two million people, nearly the entire population of the Gaza Strip, were also displaced at the end of last year. Worldwide, close to 10 million people were displaced within their countries at the end of last year, after being forced to flee by disasters.

A full 65.8 million new internal displacements were meanwhile reported in 2024.

Conflict was responsible for 20.1 million of those fresh displacements, while a record 45.8 million people fled their homes to escape disasters. — AFP

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